patria turned quickly into a nightmare." "The Cuban proletariat discovered that, for them, the transition from colony to republic meant a descent into destitution."[23] The boom and bust was inherent in the economy's overdependence on one product.

Foreign domination and widespread poverty contributed to another essential characteristic of pre-revolutionary Cuba: corruption. With few economic alternatives, Cubans turned to an increasingly corrupt public sector for enrichment, or for survival. "By 1925 corruption was an integral part of republican Cuba's daily economic and political life," write Sergio Díaz-Briquets and Jorge Pérez-López. "Low-level officials, often appointed as political patronage, depended on petty corruption to supplement meager salaries or accumulate savings, given their lack of job security in a highly politicized civil service. And just as petty corruption was rampant, so was grand corruption. To survive and prosper, businesses had to 'take care' of public officials. The most ambitious and entrepreneurial, ironically, looked to political corruption."[24] In the 1920s, "the spectacle of republican politics was played before an incredulous national audience. There seemed to be no limit to political abuses, no end to revelations of spectacular graft and accounts of official corruption in all branches" of government.[25]

Resentment against the status quo, and especially Cuban subordination to the United States, coalesced in the 1920s in a number of artistic and intellectual movements that challenged both Eurocentrism and U.S. domination with a revitalized Cuban nationalism. Cuban intellectuals were finally following José Martí's advice, and concentrating not only on Martí himself, but on a spectrum of authors from "Our America," challenging the idea of U.S. and European superiority. They were also reading critical U.S. and European authors, ranging from Marx, Engels, Trotsky, and Stalin, to those in the United States like Scott Nearing, Joseph Freeman, and Leland H. Jenks, who denounced U.S. imperialism in Cuba.

The intellectual currents of the 1920s incorporated a new valorization of things African, including, especially, the African-influenced musical genre of *son*. "In the context of the barrage of North American